on such cooperation, and the degree to which states and institutions of global governance possess power in the international system. Further, our study carries lessons for practitioners who seek to strengthen multilateral cooperation in the face of widespread resistance.

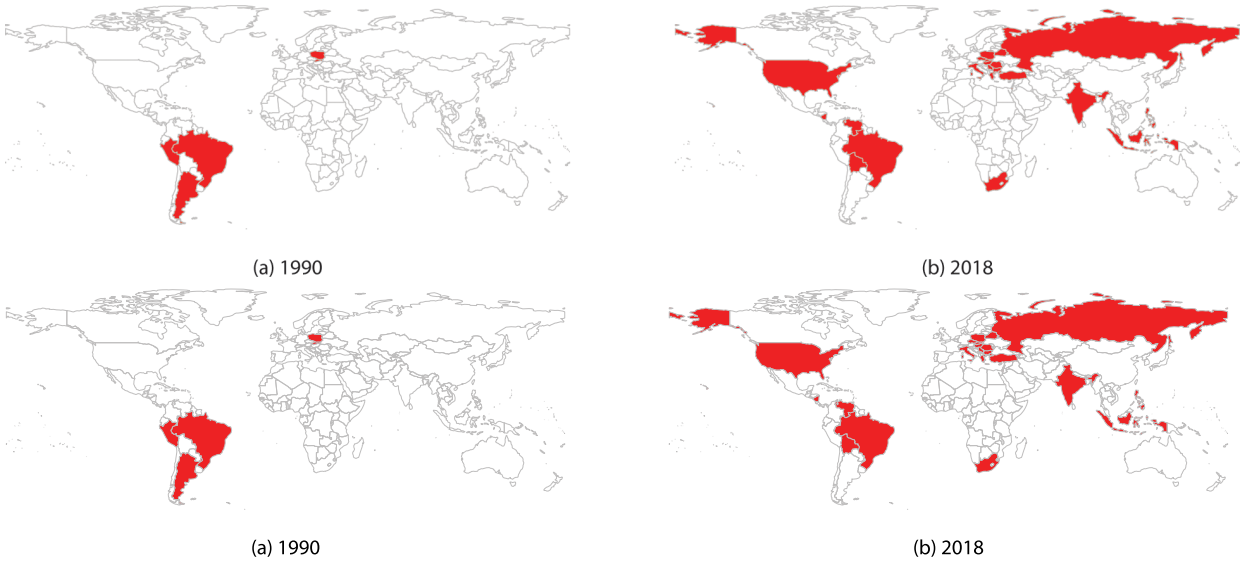


FIGURE 1.1. The rise of populism. These maps show countries with populist leaders in 1990 and 2018, highlighting populism's spread. Data comes from Funke, Schularick, and Trebesch (2023).

Our primary contention is that IOs are strategic actors that can—and do—combat attacks by hostile actors, allowing them to remain much more resilient than they are often given credit for. We thus push against the considerable scholarship on global governance that overlooks IO agency, which argues that IOs "do not take on a life of their own, and thus … are simply tools of the great powers" (Mearsheimer 2019). Others argue that IOs possess authority only within narrow bounds, restricted by the limited degree to which member states delegate responsibilities to them (Keohane 1984; Pollack 1997; Abbott and Snidal 1998). Even when IOs' agency is acknowledged, scholars have difficulty applying these insights to derive specific, testable predictions about IO behavior.

In contrast, we show that IOs leverage and innovate tools to push back against detractors. We adapt insights from organizational sociology and the study of bureaucracies to the international context to identify the tools in IOs' foreign policy toolkits. Unlike countries' coercive strategies, IOs'